light up

Light Up is a playful, interdisciplinary platform for mental health engagement via research and the creative arts.

scope	ux research, front-end interface design, back-end workflow infrastructure, publishing system
role	lead ux researcher & system designer
tools	figma, indesign, html/css prototyping
timeline	10 weeks
year	spring 2023



the challenge

Youth needed a unified system that allowed them to share, explore, and reflect without feeling clinical or remote.

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context

Mental health resources on campus were fragmented: articles on dispersed blogs, events buried in newsletters, and artwork isolated in exhibitions. This fragmentation diluted impact and reinforced stigma by positioning mental health as a specialty domain rather than a part of everyday discourse. **The goal was to design a platform that made engagement natural, inviting, and culturally embedded**.

competitive & ecosystem analysis

Before ideation, I analyzed several existing platforms to identify gaps and opportunities:

category	strengths	limitations	insights
Medium / Substack-style publication platforms	Strong content flow, accessible publishing tools.	Lack of event or community integration.	Integrate peer-authored publishing with human warmth and cultural relevance.
Campus wellness portals	Centralized information, institutional authority.	Overly formal and clinical; discourages casual engagement.	Use approachable visuals and language to reduce intimidation and encourage participation.
Mental health apps (e.g. Headspace)	High-polish UX; well-structured routines for individuals.	Highly individualistic; focused on solitary coping mechanisms.	Shift from self-care to community care by designing shared, cross-disciplinary spaces.

empathize & define - ux research

I conducted interviews with 12 students, ran two surveys with 60 respondents, and audited all existing wellness and campus media channels at my school in Singapore and Benicia, CA. My key insights were:

Students preferred peer narratives over institutional messaging.

School wellness articles felt impersonal, prompting a peer-led publishing system that prioritized student authorship and modern relevance.

Aesthetic tone determined emotional safety.

Clinical interfaces felt alienating. Students preferred “soft” and “playful” visuals. This led to the creation of cartoon ambassadors that embodied emotional accessibility and eased onboarding.

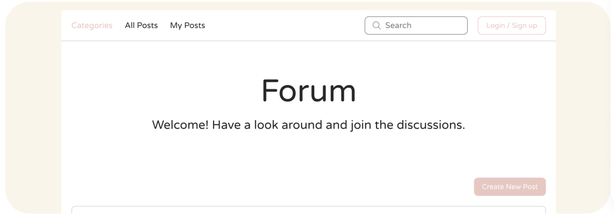
Discovery must feel ambient.

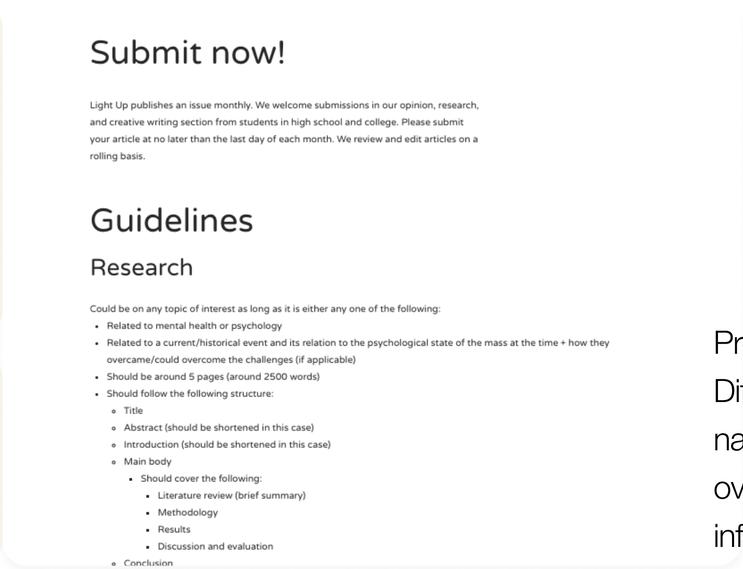
Event awareness was often below 10% when pushed by email alone. This led to homepage event spotlights and a rotating banner engine to make content discovery organic.

ideation

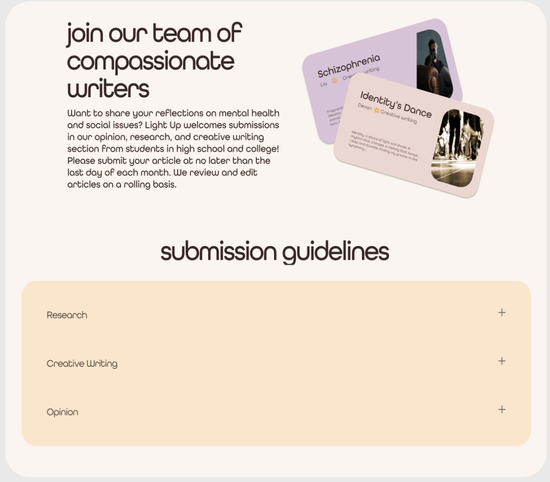
I tested multiple conceptual directions, including anonymous sharing boards and a forum for questions and answers. Yet, I was faced with an overly complex menu, lack of visuals, and unappealing organization of information. The final concept balanced structure with play — a modular tri-system (articles, events, art) connected by friendly ambassadors who reframe mental health as creative expression.



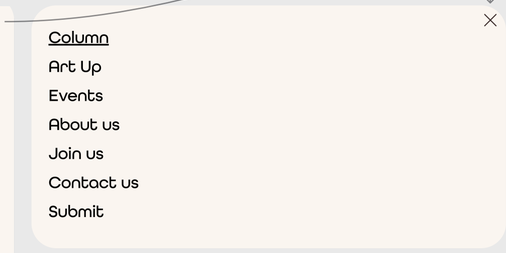




Prototype 1:
Difficult to navigate due to overwhelming information.



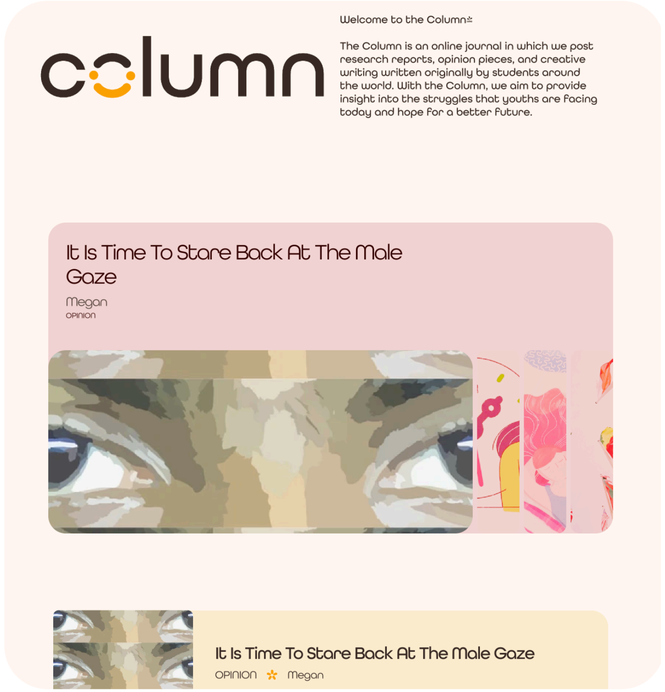




New Prototype:
More UI focused, clear information hierarchy.

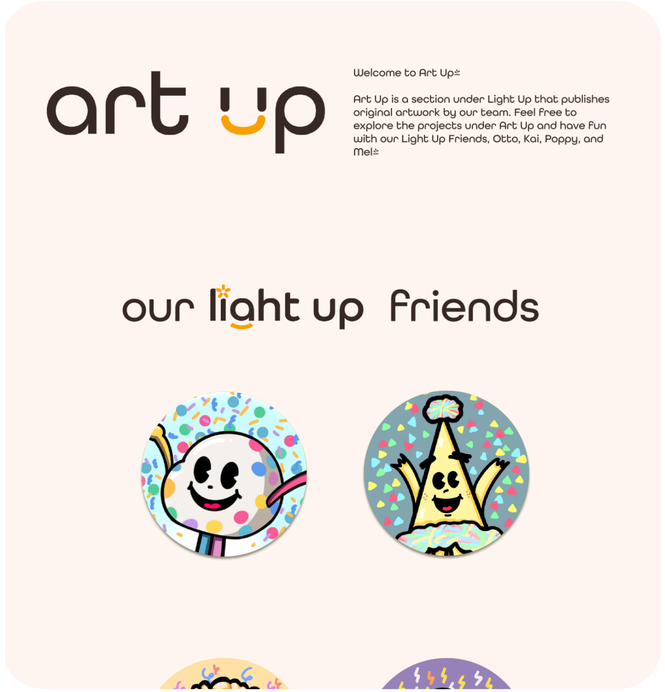
system architecture & execution

I built Light Up as a modular three-tier system:



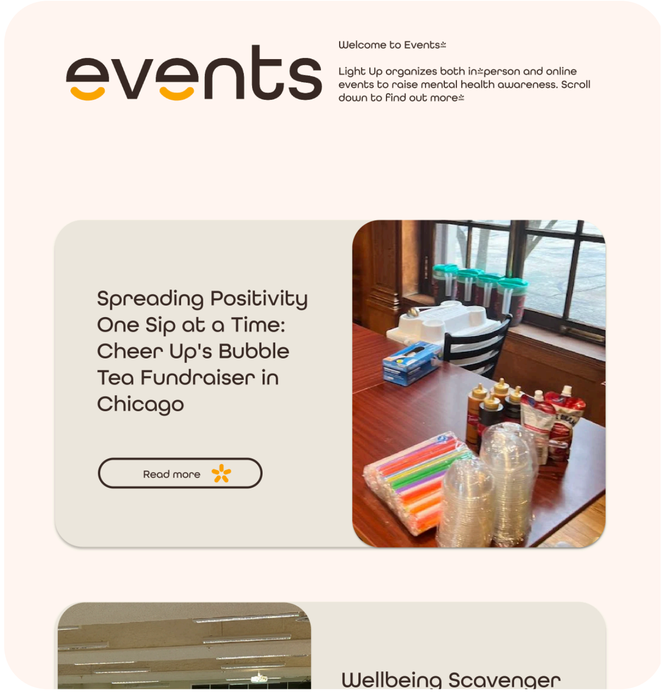
Content Module

Article submission, moderation, and publishing workflow



Gallery Module

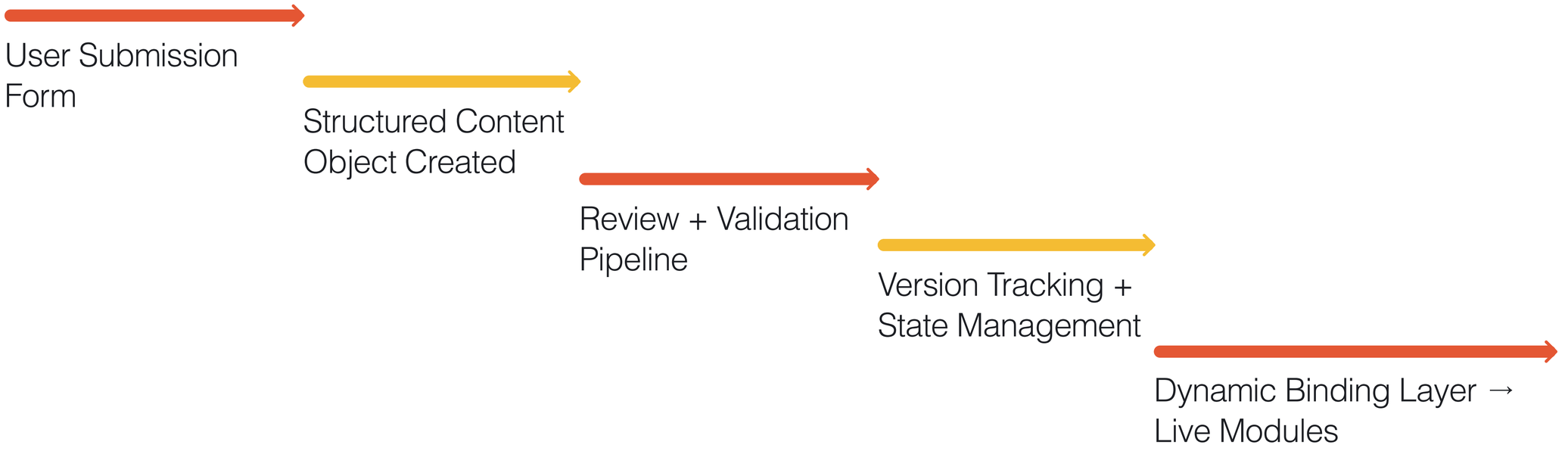
Upload, rendering, and archiving of student artwork



Events Module

Categorized blog page for event updates

On the front-end, I implemented a **modular IA**, **unified color system**, and **ambassador illustrations** for accessibility and warmth. On the back-end, a **lightweight CMS framework** manages the full content lifecycle. Structured collections with metadata for versioning and visibility feed directly into front-end components via dynamic bindings and state management, ensuring real-time synchronization. Editorial moderation, version tracking, and analytics-driven visibility logic sustain content quality and scalability beyond the initial deployment.



test + impact

The platform launched publicly in May 2023 and engaged over 300 students in its first phase. Students described the platform as “inviting,” “creative,” and “safe.” Ambassadors successfully humanized the interface, reducing perceived stigma.

+27.5%

Event participation and awareness

2.5×

Gallery revisit rate

2x

Article submission volume

tigerlaunch

Tigerlaunch is the world's largest student-run entrepreneurship competition based in Princeton University.

scope	branding & social media marketing, front-end interface design
role	branding team lead of a team of 4
tools	figma, adobe illustrator
timeline	1 year
year	fall 2024 - present



context & challenge

As the world's largest student-run entrepreneurship competition, TigerLaunch needed a coherent identity that **balanced youthful energy with professionalism**. Its **existing branding was fragmented** with new members using inconsistent logos, typography, and layouts, leading to diluted recognition and inefficient production cycles. The challenge was to establish a **modular design system** that could **unify communications** across global regions while retaining **flexibility for local adaptation**.

competitive & ecosystem analysis

Before ideation, I analyzed existing platforms to map the ecosystem and identify opportunities:

category	strengths	limitations
Hult Prize / Startup Week	High production quality, strong storytelling	Reliant on centralized design teams; limited flexibility for student organizations
Student Innovation Councils	Adaptable, decentralized	Often lacked cohesion or professional polish
Corporate brands (Stripe, Notion, Slack)	Robust governance, modular design libraries	Over-engineered for smaller, student teams

From this, the opportunity was clear: **build a lightweight, codified system that ensures consistency without sacrificing agility**.



Logo & Symbolism

The updated logomark merges “T” and “L” into a geometric monogram symbolizing structure and collaboration. Built on a strict grid, it ensures legibility and scalability across media.



Typography

The Montserrat family was selected for its geometric clarity and approachable tone, with defined weights (Regular to Bold) for hierarchy.



Color System

A minimal palette of Princeton orange (FF5200) and amber (F89E1C) paired with neutral white and black enables contrast and energy while maintaining institutional alignment.



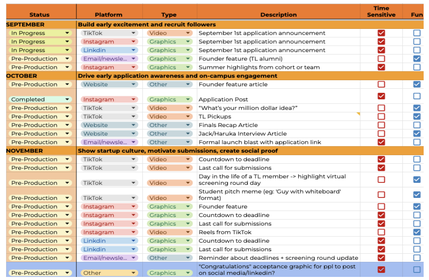
Layout & Grid

A responsive grid architecture defines spacing, logo clear-space ratios, and typography scales, ensuring consistency across print and digital.

Branding Applications & Impact

I spearheaded a new social media plan that reaps the benefits of a structured visual system; each module is pre-templated to minimize production time. Now, TigerLaunch is active on a weekly basis on Instagram, TikTok, LinkedIn, and email newsletters. **The new system reduced design turnaround time by 30%, increased social engagement by 15%.**

Month	Campaign Focus	Vibe
September	Apps open + recruiting	Serious
October	Back-to-Campus: new TL team + pickups content + drive application awareness	Fun
November	Applications wrap up: startup culture + last call	Serious
December	Holiday excitement: team culture + looking ahead (regionals)	Fun
January	Going international: regionals/trips	Fun/Serious
February	Domestic regionals: regionals/trips + finalists determined	Fun/Serious
March	Hyping up for finals: building up excitement + focus on team	Fun
April	Finals: finals + results + wrap-up	Serious



Status	Platform	Type	Description	Time Sensitive	Fun
SEPTEMBER	Build early excitement and recruit followers				
In Progress	TikTok	Video	September 1st application announcement	☑	☐
In Progress	Instagram	Graphics	September 1st application announcement	☑	☐
In Progress	LinkedIn	Graphics	September 1st application announcement	☑	☐
Pre-Production	Email/newsle...	Graphics	Founder feature (TL alumni)	☐	☑
Pre-Production	Instagram	Graphics	Summer highlights from cohort or team	☑	☐
OCTOBER	Drive early application awareness and on-campus engagement				
Pre-Production	Website	Other	Founder feature article	☐	☑
Completed	Instagram	Graphics	Application Post	☑	☐
Pre-Production	TikTok	Video	"What's your million dollar idea?"	☐	☑
Pre-Production	TikTok	Video	TL Pickups	☐	☑
Pre-Production	Website	Other	Finals Recap Article	☐	☐
Pre-Production	Website	Other	Jack/Haruka Interview Article	☐	☑
Pre-Production	Email/newsle...	Other	Formal launch blast with application link	☑	☐
NOVEMBER	Show startup culture, motivate submissions, create social proof				
Pre-Production	TikTok	Video	Countdown to deadline	☑	☐
Pre-Production	TikTok	Video	Last call for submissions	☑	☐
Pre-Production	TikTok	Video	Day in the life of a TL member -> highlight virtual screening round day	☐	☑
Pre-Production	TikTok	Video	Student pitch meme (eg: 'Guy with whiteboard' format)	☐	☑
Pre-Production	Instagram	Graphics	Founder feature	☐	☑
Pre-Production	Instagram	Graphics	Countdown to deadline	☑	☐
Pre-Production	Instagram	Graphics	Last call for submissions	☑	☐
Pre-Production	Instagram	Video	Reels from TikTok	☐	☑
Pre-Production	LinkedIn	Graphics	Countdown to deadline	☑	☐
Pre-Production	LinkedIn	Graphics	Last call for submissions	☑	☐
Pre-Production	Email/newsle...	Other	Reminder about deadlines + screening round update	☑	☐
Pre-Production	Other	Graphics	"Congratulations" acceptance graphic for ppl to post on social media/linkedin?	☑	☐